DEFENCE

Farewell to a Supersonic Legend

AFTER SIX DECADES AS THE BACKBONE OF INDIAN AIR DEFENCE, THE MiG-21 TOOK ITS FINAL BOW ON SEPTEMBER 26

Inducted into the Indian Air Force (IAF) in 1963, the Soviet-designed Mikoyan-Gurevich or MiG-21 revolutionised Indian air combat with its supersonic speed. A versatile multirole fighter—originally designed as an interceptor and later adapted for air superiority, ground attack and combat air patrol missions—it eventually gained all-weather capability. From the India-Pakistan War of 1971 to the Kargil conflict in 1999, it proved its mettle and shaped generations of fighter pilots. Yet this storied legacy has also been marred by over 450 crashes over the decades. On September 26, the IAF formally retired this iconic warhorse in Chandigarh, marking the end of an era.

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900+
Total MiG-21s inducted into the IAF since 1963; 840 built in India

400
Peak fleet strength (approx.), across 19 IAF squadrons, in the 1980s-90s

2,500
KMPH
or Mach 2.05 (supersonic) speed at high altitudes

THE LONG HAUL

1955
First flight of the MiG-21 in the erstwhile Soviet Union

1961
India signs tech-transfer deal with the USSR

1963
First batch of MiG-21s inducted; No. 28 Squadron 'The First Supersonics' raised at Chandigarh

1965
Limited use in the India-Pakistan War

1966
HAL starts building the MiG-21 (FL and later M and bis variants) under licence

1971
The India-Pakistan War sees first supersonic dogfights in South Asia; MiG-21s down at least 8 PAF fighters and help secure air superiority

1999
Close air support and patrols during the Kargil War; strike Pakistani positions in high-altitude terrain

